The Towel Lady

By Janet S. Tiger

A woman comes onto the stage with a basket of laundry, which she puts down heavily. Then she takes a towel from the basket, and she stops, turning to the audience, holding the towel in a kind reverie.

INTRODUCTION

How do you know if you are better off staying married or getting a divorce? Sometimes a marriage is worth saving and sometimes it isn't. Sometimes people keep trying to make sense out of something that doesn't make sense or can't be solved. If you throw in the towel, you stop trying because you have found that you won't succeed. More than 50% of marriages in the United States today end with one or both partners throwing in the proverbial towel. The most common conclusion is divorce; but, of course, there are always other alternatives . . .

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THE TOWEL LADY: **(Pg 45-48)** You know, a new towel is a wonderful thing. Come on, you ladies all know what I'm talking about! Now, I can understand why the men are muttering to themselves, because no man can appreciate a good towel. But you ladies know what I'm saying is true! Only another woman knows what I'm talkin' about. *(She holds out the towel to illustrate)*

Isn't it beautiful when it's brand new? It's so soft and good smellin'. It has a youthful way about it, kinda sassy, but innocent. You men are sittin' there wonderin' why the hell you came to listen to some old woman talk about the laundry, but if you listened for once in your lives, maybe you'd learn something.

See this towel? I just bought it today. It ain't never been touched by any hands 'cept mind. Well, maybe somebody touched it in the store first, but since I didn't see it and it didn't leave no mark, it don't matter. *(beat)(Examining edges)* It's perfect. I never buy those "seconds" with their funny lines down the middle and the frayed bottoms. They don't last

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as long. I buy one hunnert per cent thick cotton Cannon towels made for J C Penney. The thirsty ones. *(beat)*

Men never did understand towels. And that's because they treat their towels just like they treat their women. Here's this beautiful towel which I'll put carefully onta my towel rack. And I'll be real sure that my hands are washed clean when I use it, so's all that gets on it is water. *(beat)*

(She turns ornery) But a man'll come in from working on some greasy car for three hours and he'll. . . he'll *(She can barely bring herself to say the words)* . . . he'll take those greasy, filthy hands and put them onto that clean, pure towel.. and. . . and that towel will never be the same! No matter how I wash that towel with soap, that dirt gets right down into the fibers. And if I bleach that towel, all the newness comes right out with the grease!

And once that towel is besmirched, I dunno, it's downhill from there. But even though that towel isn't pure no more, it lasts and lasts, and that man puts more and more greasy dirt onto it, and I bleach more 'n more of the life outa it *(beat)*
But just like a woman, it keeps doing what it has to do. Not complainin', just sittin' there. Until one day there's a hole in it. Not a big one, mind ya, but it's there. When you point it out to them, they just say, *(She imitates a man's voice)* So what? Lotsa good use in it. . .

(Back to herself) But you can't put it out fer company no more. Naw, it gets put to the back of the closet, to be used for wipin' babies and cleanin' up after the dog. *(beat)* And then one day, *(She shudders to think about it)* you go to get the towel to wipe up some jam that spilled onta the carpet, and it's gone.. You can't find it nowhere. You take all the other towels out, but there ain't hide nor hair of it.

So you ask him *(Sweetly).* Honey did you see that towel, the one with the pretty yeller flowers on it? And he says, *(Imitates man's voice)* You mean that old faded thing with holes in it. *(Back to herself)* And that's when you know the truth. You go out to the garage, and

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there ya see it, hanging on a nail, just like Jesus. And it's just not mildly stained anymore, it's COVERED with disgusting marks that you don't even want to know what the origins were. And you look at that poor, faithful towel, and it's enough to make your heart just bleed! *(beat)*

(She's quiet now and holds the towel like a baby.) And so you go inside to your husband's desk, and you take his thirty-eight, and you shoot him right through the heart. *(A pause to let this sink in, then she is cheerful again.) (Beat)* And then you wait for the police to come and get you. *(Put down towel carefully, reverently. We hear a distant voice, calling from offstage. She listens, then responds to the voice.)*

I'll be there in just a minute, Officer Williams. I just have one more thing to hang out. *(She takes the last shirt out of the basket and hangs it up. It has a hole in it surrounded by a big red stain. She turns to the audience and smiles, then takes the basket and walks offstage.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Janet S. Tiger
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AWARD HISTORY

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